and backed by air power could blockade and raid China's overseas ports. In any case, the bulk of the Chinese navy will have to transit the Malacca, Sunda, Lombok, and other straits. The Malacca Strait is particularly important because it has deep waters, and it cuts sailing times to the Indian Ocean the most. On the other hand, it is a narrow strip of water and is nearest to India. It is therefore vulnerable to being closed by the Indian navy. This would not be an easy operation, and much depends on how long and effectively closure can be enforced, yet the threat of bottling up the strait is another reason that the Chinese navy's superiority is exaggerated.

Nuclear Balance

Beyond conventional weapons, what is the tally of nuclear weapons? In 2020, India had about 150 nuclear weapons of various sizes whereas China had 320. Both countries have a triad – nuclear weapons that can be launched from the air, land, and sea. India's triad is very new, and most of its nuclear force is on air- and land-based platforms: 118 of 150 devices are air- and ground-launched. China's triad is much older, and the overwhelming part of it is land- and sea-based: 220 of 320 devices are on land and sea.[27] In total, China has twice the number of devices as India, but this may not constitute a decisive edge. With nuclear weapons, it does not take a large arsenal to deter the other side from launching an attack. Nuclear weapons can be used against population centres and against the other side's nuclear weapons – or both at the same time. Attacking India's population centres is suicidal because it would invite Indian retaliation against Chinese cities and towns. Attacking India's nuclear weapons is just as suicidal. Since China cannot destroy India's nuclear arsenal in a first strike, it must once again be prepared to face a retaliatory strike targeting its population centres. Finally, following from the above, China does not have enough nuclear weapons to simultaneously attack major Indian population centres and disarm India's nuclear arsenal. If it tried to do so, it would be devastated by retaliatory strikes.